



This stone relief is from the Chinese Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms period. Breakdown of central authority in the period led to economic contraction.

TANG CHINA HAD BEEN IN MILITARY DECLINE since defeat by the Arabs at the Battle of Talas River in 751–760, and the **Huang Zhao rebellion** of the 880s signaled the end of the dynasty. **Zhuwen** (c. 852–912) was a warlord who had originally been part of the Huang Zhao uprising and then instrumental in the rebel defeat. Richly rewarded for his role, he steadily built up his power base until in 904 he was ready to seize control, **executing the Tang emperor Zhaozong** and most of his sons, and installing the emperor's 13-year-old son on the throne as a puppet ruler. In 907, he took the throne for himself, founding the **Later Liang Dynasty**, but although he controlled the northern heartland of China—the Yellow River Valley region of Huang He—he was unable to prevent the south from

fragmenting into ten independent kingdoms. The Later Liang Dynasty was short-lived (907–923), with a succession of groups seizing control of the Huang He region and founding dynasties of their own, but proving unable to hold on to power. This period of anarchy, known as the Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms, lasted until the establishment of the **Northern Song Dynasty** (see 951–960), and was a time of great hardship. Authority broke down, the economy collapsed, and barter replaced money in many areas. There was extensive flood and famine as flood defenses and irrigation works fell into disrepair.

To the west and north of the Five Dynasties region, **Shatuo Turks** and **Khitans** consolidated kingdoms of their own. The Khitans of southern Manchuria established their empire in 905 under the leadership of Yelü Abaoji (872–926). He went on to declare himself emperor in 916, founding the **Liao Dynasty**, which lasted until 1125, including a brief period as one of the Five Dynasties controlling northern China.

In 909, Sa'id ibn-Husayn, an Ismaili Shi'ite, overthrew the **Sunni Aghlabid Dynasty** in Kairouan (modern-day Tunisia), declared himself **al-Mahdi** (the Shi'ite messiah), and **founded the Fatimid Dynasty**, named for the daughter of the prophet Muhammad, from whom he claimed descent.

The **Abbey of Cluny** in Burgundy, founded in 910 by William the

ABBEY OF CLUNY

William the Pious, who donated the land for the abbey in 910, placed no obligations on its Benedictine monks, so that it was free from secular oversight and answerable only to the Pope. Cluny became the center of a monastic empire of great power, governing around 10,000 monks. In 1098, Pope Urban II, a former Abbot of Cluny, declared it “the light of the world.”



Pious, Duke of Aquitaine, became the center of a **monastic “empire”** in Europe (see panel, above).

Displaced westward by the Pechenegs (see 891–900), the **Magyars** launched a series of devastating **raids** throughout the decade. In 901, they ravaged

Carinthia, in 906 and 907 they wreaked havoc in Moravia, and in 908 they attacked Bavaria, Saxony, and Thuringia. With the Frankish emperor unwilling or unable to help, the East Franks elected regional “dukes” to defend against the incursions.

The Five Dynasties

A succession of regimes was unable to consolidate power, leaving warlords to the north and south to set up independent kingdoms. The fractured geopolitical situation is reflected in this map, which shows a tangle of borders and states.



KEY

- Chinese states
- States occupied by non-Chinese peoples

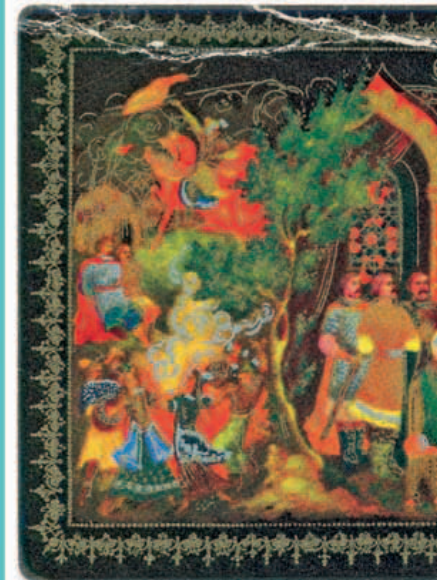


ABD AL-RAHMAN III BECAME THE NEW Umayyad ruler of the **Córdoba emirate** on the death of his grandfather, Abdallah, in 912. His territories had been reduced by rebellions and he quickly set about regaining much of his lost kingdom. During his reign and that of his successors, **Córdoba** reached the peak of its power (see 921–930).

According to traditional sources, **Prince Igor, ruler of Kievan Rus** from 914–945, was the son of the legendary Rurik, who founded **Novgorod** in 862. Under his protection, **Kievan Rus** (see 881–890) became a

Igor I of Kiev

Igor, who ruled from 914 until his death in 945, gestures to his court in this 19th-century illustration.



Fatimid era text

Named for Muhammad's daughter, **Fatima**, the Fatimids proved patrons of learning through their sponsorship of Cairo's **al-Azhar school**.

